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Description	Mandrake	Lycoris/LX	Xandros	SuSe 9.1 Pro	ELX	RHEL WS
Ease Of Use (Weightage: 60%)	38.5	35	26	45	39	40
Installation (Scale of 5)	4	3	3	4	3.5	4
Partitioning (Scale of 5)	4	3.5	3	4	4	4
Auto mount Windows partition	N	Y	N	Y	Y	N
Windows key support	N	N	Y	N	N	N
Update process (Scale of 5)	3.5	2.5	NA	4	2.5	4
Number of CDs	3	1	1	5	1	4
Common applications (Weightage: 10%)	9	10	7	10	6	7
Address management	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	N
Organiser	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	N
Fax	Y	Y	N	Y	N	Y
Messenger	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y
MP3 player	N	Y	Y	Y	Y	N
Games bundled	Y	Y	Y	Y	N	Y
Networking (Weightage: 15%)	10.5	10.5	12	12.5	11	10.5
Configuration (Scale of 5)	3.5	3.5	4	4	4.5	4
Share folder (Scale of 5)	4	3.5	4	4	3	3
Access other remote share (Scale of 5)	3	3.5	4	4.5	3.5	3.5
Printing (Weightage: 15%)	8.5	10.5	12	11	9	11
Configuration (Scale of 5)	3.5	3.5	4	4	3.5	4
Share printer (Scale of 5)	2.5	3.5	4	3.5	1	4
Install remote printer (Scale of 5)	2.5	3.5	4	3.5	4.5	3
Final Score	66.5	66	57	78.5	65	68.5

select any remotely shared printer that you want to use. The printing configuration of Xandros in the ‘First Run Wizard’ was excellent; it helped set up not only a local printer but also a network printer without any trouble. This GUI tool was the best across all distributions—it even allows one-click sharing of the printer on the local machine.

Due to problems with Samba for Red Hat, you may not be able to install remote printers or share your own printers. The configuration tool doesn’t provide a scan or browse button to add remote printers. You need to manually enter the domain, machine and share names.

Recover it yourself

Even now, rescuing is done the old way—using the command line. If the system has only one Linux OS, the rescue mode mounts the Linux partition, by default, at `/mnt/sysimage`. If multiple Linux OSes are loaded, it has a tough time detecting the right one. RHEL takes the safest way out by presenting a drop down list; ELX mounts, but with warnings, while others such as SuSE and Xandros do not take the trouble of mounting a partition.

Auto mounting CD-ROM and floppy drives

Both Red Hat and Xandros auto-mount a CD-ROM drive when a disc is inserted—Red Hat provides a shortcut on the desktop, while Xandros opens the file manager with the CD drive in focus. Other

OSes auto-mount the CD drive when the file manager tries to access them. Surprisingly, SuSE has changed the default mounting location of CD drives and floppies from `/mnt` to `/media`. Just press the eject button—the CD-ROM auto un-mounts and ejects the disk. As for floppies, it’s best to mount when the file manager tries to access it, and not after inserting the disk.

USB reaction

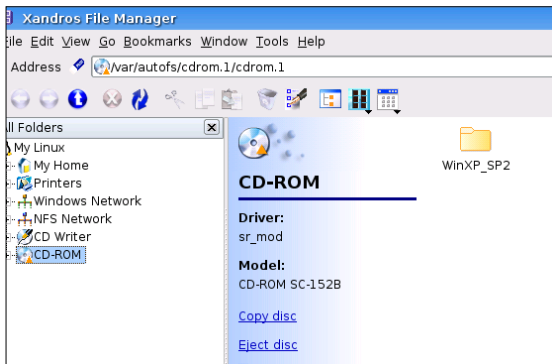
Xandros has a pop-up notification when it detects a printer attached to the USB port. For other distributions, you get immediate response for a USB keyboard or mouse but for a printer, scanner or USB drives, you need to execute a few commands. ELX was a disappointment—it does not support USB!

Dial-Up Connection

Xandros has an excellent GUI tool to set up the modem and dial-up

SuSE’s auto update indicates whether a patch is critical or optional

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As soon as you insert a CD-ROM, the File Manager pops up in Xandros